

Severe Weather and Tornado Response

Policy Number	POL-EM-051	Owner / Department	Emergency Management
Effective Date	2023-05-15	Version	2.3
Last Revised	2026-02-14	Next Review	2028-02-14
Approved By	Emergency Management Committee	Applies To	All staff, patients, and visitors in all buildings; coordinated through the House Supervisor and HICS

1. Purpose

To protect patients, staff, and visitors from injury during tornadoes, severe thunderstorms, and other high-wind events through timely monitoring, shelter-in-place, and — when warranted — activation of the Hospital Incident Command System, consistent with the CMS Emergency Preparedness Rule and The Joint Commission Emergency Management standards. Severe weather is addressed in the facility Hazard Vulnerability Analysis (HVA).

2. Scope

Applies to all facility buildings and grounds. The House Supervisor (or designee) monitors National Weather Service alerts for the county and initiates the actions below on a watch or warning.

3. Definitions

- **Tornado Watch** — conditions are favorable for tornadoes; prepare and monitor.
- **Tornado Warning** — a tornado has been sighted or indicated by radar; take shelter immediately.
- **Shelter-in-place** — moving occupants to designated interior, lowest-feasible-floor areas away from windows and exterior walls.
- **Safe areas** — pre-identified interior corridors, stairwell cores, and interior rooms without exterior glass, marked on unit emergency maps.

4. Procedure

IMPORTANT — On a Tornado Warning, move patients, staff, and visitors away from all windows and exterior walls into designated interior safe areas on the lowest feasible floor, close doors, and have everyone crouch low and protect their heads. Do not use elevators. Non-transportable critical patients are sheltered in place with blankets/mattresses for shielding.

Alert	Actions
Tornado Watch	House Supervisor notifies units; identify safe areas and shelter routes; charge bed/equipment batteries; close blinds; prepare to move patients.

Alert	Actions
Tornado Warning	Announce overhead; move occupants to interior safe areas away from glass; close all doors; shield non-transportable patients; account for staff; consider HICS activation.
All Clear	House Supervisor / Incident Commander announces all clear; assess for damage, injuries, and utility loss; return occupants; document.

5. Severity & Reporting

Severe-weather impacts are classified under POL-RM-013. Structural damage, loss of a utility, or any patient/staff injury is **SEV-1**: notify the Administrator-on-Call and Safety Officer immediately and within 1 hour, and activate HICS. A warning that required shelter-in-place without injury or damage is documented as a **SEV-3** operational event within 24 hours; near misses (e.g., unsecured exterior equipment identified during a watch) are reported within 24 hours.

6. Documentation Requirements

- Alert type and time received; time shelter-in-place was initiated and lifted.
- Units sheltered and whether any patients were moved; staff/patient accounting.
- Injuries, structural damage, and utility impacts identified on the post-event survey.
- HICS activation status and notifications made.

7. References

- CMS Emergency Preparedness Rule, 42 CFR 482.15 (all-hazards risk assessment / HVA).
- The Joint Commission, Emergency Management (EM) standards — mitigation and response.
- National Weather Service watch/warning definitions.
- Related: POL-RM-013 (severity & reporting), POL-EM-053 (HICS / Code Triage), POL-EM-054 (utility failure).